

France: Fears of far-right vs far-left runoff are premature

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France

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Le Pen dominates, but fears of runoff against far left are premature

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Short-term trajectory:

Long-term trajectory:

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The French presidential campaign has entered a critical new phase with Marine Le Pen still leading the polls; Le Pen performed poorly on her weakest issue, the economy, in the first TV debate last week but remains far ahead of the field with 34%-35% of first-round support.

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Far left leader Jean-Luc Melenchon has risen in some polls this summer, but suggestions that he is on course to face Le Pen in a runoff between the political extremes on 2 May are premature.

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Eurasia Group's probability tree gives Le Pen a 35% chance of victory, but we still give a slight edge—at 40%—to the strongest mainstream candidate, former centrist prime minister Edouard Philippe.

The de facto opening of the campaign went badly for the runaway, first-round favorite. Le Pen, confronted with questions about French debt and the economy during a seven-candidate TV debate staged by the French employers' organization, mostly rehashed incoherent proposals for low taxes and high social spending from her failed 2022 campaign.

Before the debate on 27 August, Le Pen acrimoniously parted ways with her economic adviser, Francois Durvy, who had been pushing her toward an orthodox right-wing position on low taxes and restrained social spending. She announced that, if elected president, she would follow the approach of no borrowing to finance current expenditure. But she maintained her costly proposal to lower the state pension age to 62 (and 60 for some), while offering no credible spending cuts.

Given France's persistently high deficits and growing concerns about debt sustainability, her remarks prompted harsh criticism in the French media. One commentator gave her a score of seven out of 20.

The economy may yet prove to be Le Pen's Achilles heel. So far, she has countered attacks by pointing to the poor debt record of President Emmanuel Macron's post-pandemic governments. In an Elabe poll taken after the debate, she remained the overwhelming favorite to win the first round on 18 April with 34%-35% of the vote. Le Pen's internal party critics say that she is determined to stay close to the blue-collar part of her electoral base and is refusing to accept that, to build a winning coalition in round two, she will need to reassure middle-class and wealthier voters that she will not further weaken the

already struggling French economy.

Speculation that Melenchon could clinch a runoff spot alongside Le Pen is premature. August polls showing Melenchon's first-round support rising to 16% sparked fevered commentary in French and foreign media, but they are misleading. Polls showed Melenchon reaching the second round only if the centrist vote split, which is exceedingly unlikely. An informal understanding exists between two former centrist prime ministers, Philippe and Gabriel Attal, that only one will remain in the race after February.

Melenchon's polling has been trending upward, but an Elabe poll taken for La Tribune Dimanche last weekend showed him slipping back to 14%. Overall, the polls' trajectory remains in line with our basecase—a Le Pen versus Philippe runoff. In the Elabe poll at the weekend, Philippe had 17%-20.5% of the first-round vote and was by far the closest of any candidate to Le Pen in round two, losing 47.5% to 52.5%.

Philippe's path to the runoff remains uncertain. The strongest performer in the first TV debate, judging by media reaction and applause from the business audience, was Attal. Both men performed well, but Attal was wittier and had more punch. Philippe had hoped that his rival would be forced out by poor polling scores by November or December. Attal may now be emboldened to stay in the race until the New Year. He has started to attack Philippe directly, accusing him of representing "20-year-old ideas."

Pressure has returned for a formal primary of the right and center, but both Philippe and Attal prefer the so-called wild primary of the opinion polls. As a result, Philippe's first-round strategy has shifted. On issues such as migration and the economy, he is now running as a candidate of the traditional right, his political family before he became Macron's first prime minister in 2017. He hopes to widen his lead over Attal by drawing away support from Bruno Retailleau, the leader of the center-right Republicans.

Eurasia Group still sees a Philippe victory next May as the basecase. Our probability tree gives Le Pen a 35% chance of victory compared with 40% for Philippe.

As last year, the budget for 2027 will pass via the use of emergency powers. Meanwhile, the accelerating campaign will complicate attempts to pass a deficit-cutting budget for 2027. Without a majority in the National Assembly, Prime Minister Sebastien Lecornu faces the same budgetary impasse that has brought down three French governments in the last two years. Lecornu will present a budget draft at the end of this month that is expected to propose only a modest cut in the deficit from 5% of GDP to 4.9%. Even that will probably require the use of emergency powers under Article 49.3 of the constitution.

The 2025 and 2026 budgets were eventually passed two months late after the Socialist Party agreed not to back an Article 49.3 censure vote. The Socialists—or alternatively Le Pen's far right—will be reluctant to help the minority, centrist government again. Even so, a government collapse in December, four months before the presidential election, would benefit no one.

Happy to discuss,

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